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Frank Tiberi

A longtime key member of the Woody Herman saxophone section, Frank Tiberi eventually led the group after the passing of its founder. Now in his ninth decade, Frank distinguishes himself as a Coltrane scholar, and passes on his knowledge to young saxophonists at Berklee.

Frank was interviewed via Zoom on March 30, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm pleased to have Frank Tiberi with me today. And I want to congratulate you on your lengthy and productive career.

FT: Well I appreciate you having me and I feel very interesting actually — just as a person of interest I suppose you know. I mean I've gone through many, many years and I don't really think that I can really provide anything for anyone but we'll see.

MR: I think we'll accomplish that. I want to start, you know there's a lot of things of course on the Internet about you and here's one quote I rather stumbled upon in the Internet, and a saxophone player who said, "When I think of Frank Tiberi I think of the first track on the 'Giant Steps' LP from Woody Herman, 'La Fiesta.' I had to memorize and play that Frank Tiberi solo, it wasn't easy.

FT: Yeah well, I've heard that before.

MR: Yeah who said it was supposed to be easy.

FT: You know that "Giant Steps" actually, the chorale, I don't know whether you know Dennis Sandole, have you ever heard of him? From Philadelphia? He was one of those really very personal players. And I was studying — and actually John Coltrane studied from him for three years actually, Dennis Sandole was the guitar player. But I wrote that chorale while I was playing with him and of course I mean Bill Stapleton and I collaborated on that and wrote the jazztets.

MR: I was listening to it earlier today and those opening chords, you know the harmonized —

FT: That's the one, yes.

MR: Yes. I was trying to think, at the time, this was of course pre-Finale or Sibelius. Do those chords have a conception behind them, from one to the next?

FT: Well it's been so long you know that I created it actually and all I do right now is appreciate listening to it. No, they were just, you know, added — I don't know how he arranged it actually but you know how you put things together and they sound fine. It's hard to really distinguish exactly what the chord would be.

FT: Yeah that's true.

MR: The pre — as I said — pre-Finale, when you can't hear things back, I think there's nothing like that first experience — you write a chart, you go to all the trouble, perhaps you copy your own parts, you pass it out and that first time you hear it is rather unforgettable. At least it has been for me.

FT: Well I've experienced that by writing the one that Joe Zawinul actually — he played the "Carnavalito" on the synthesizer and I divided it up for the whole band. And that is a thing in which I really appreciated that I was able to really tackle, put it that way. And then of course I wrote "Countdown" of course, another thing which is one of my pride arrangements that I really cherish actually, and also I know Stan Getz, I wrote "Tide Land" for him, and that was another thing which was never really distributed. But these are things I appreciated actually. The — I only would write for myself if I had the soul. I know it's a little selfish but I'm not really considered an arranger like John Fedchock or Alan Broadbent, I mean Gary Anderson — these are really great arrangers. Bill Stapleton, Tony Klatka — these are all fellas that really went right to the band you know, they stayed for a while, and especially Alan Broadbent. I mean God almighty, he's written some great things.

MR: Yes. Let me take you back. I'm interested in the very start of your musical career. And I believe I read that taking up music was partly a practical thing, a family decision. You were helping make money for the family. Is that correct?

FT: Well at 15 — my father died after an accident actually — when I was 12, and at 15 I was in a club. And ironically I was singing "Caledonia" and playing the "Woodchopper's Ball" you know with a small group with a trumpet and sax. And I was making 30 dollars a week and that was supporting the family. I mean right now it's about five thousand a week.

MR: And you were playing the saxophone?

FT: Oh yeah.

MR: So I was looking at — this would have been let's say 1947 or so?

FT: Let's see. Maybe — I've got some notes over here. That would be — well '48 — well it would be that time actually. In '48 I joined Bob Chester's orchestra.

MR: So I'm looking at the pop hits from '47, around that time you have people like Ted Weems and Sammy Kaye — I mean you even have the "Too Fat Polka" by Arthur Godfrey. So my question is, if you can recall what your song list — what was the repertoire like back then?

FT: Oh that's pretty hard, really hard actually. But I mean the only thing I can remember is just a few things such as Frank Rossolino was my roommate and of course what Bob

carried along like rattled through. And every time that he wanted to play the saxophone he would stop and call the guy, which would be me, to come up and do the solo. But he was joking all around actually. He was just riding around with a Town and Country car and as I say, he was just, you know, he wasn't playing at all. But he did own a saxophone.

MR: He owned a saxophone. What was traveling like at that time, playing on this band?

FT: Well I'll tell you that, it was a '35 Chevy. It was two seats in the front and three in the back. And we traveled with our horns and we had our suits on, because we never knew when the U-Haul was going to come to the gig. But the gigs that we played there at that time actually was like being in parking lots, and fairs — you know county fairs. That was it actually. There were no ballrooms you know, like in later years like Atlantic City where you have the ballrooms — in Asbury Park you had ballrooms actually. But at that time you know things were very immature.

MR: Did you have a singer in the group?

FT: Not at that time, no.

MR: That's interesting because after the big band era the singers really became more popular but you managed to just play the gig instrumentally.

FT: Yup, yeah. I wanted to mention you know that Flip Phillips was in the band before I joined actually. So I mean he carried a lot of weight. That was the jazz band you know. That was considered the jazz band of that era.

MR: What was jazz —

FT: He had a lot — J. Monterose was on the other end of the saxophones so he had all great players — Doug Mettome — I don't know whether you know him.

MR: I have heard that name, yes.

FT: Well but we had all of them actually. You know everybody was — he had a lot of great musicians in the band actually. And a lot of them went on to be really jazz players too, like Flip Phillips.

MR: Did you have a thought at that time that this was going to be your life's work in one sense or another?

FT: Yes. But of course I mean I left the band in maybe about eight months then of course I mean I had gotten married, that's right yeah. I got married at the age of 22 and there I just started the life of you know trying to get gigs and work and actually I did mostly musical shows in Philadelphia, where I was a doubler and I played the bassoon and of course I was leading a domestic life.

MR: Okay so you were in one place for longer.

FT: For what?

FT: I lasted eight months, that was it. I had to get away from it actually.

MR: Can you recall, you said you were making 30 dollars a week — was that with Bob Chester?

FT: No that was a club that I was working in on the weekend in my hometown.

MR: So what kind of salary were you making with Bob Chester?

FT: 80 bucks a week. And that was pretty good.

MR: That was pretty good.

FT: Yeah. And that was 1948.

MR: So then you're playing shows in Philadelphia and it required you to be a good reader, punctual, and good habits. Is that a decent way to put it?

FT: Well that required it of course, because he had all the great shows come in to practice you know and to rehearse and get things together before they'd go into New York. Now the reason why I was you know one of the doublers actually was because I, at the age of oh Jeez, 30 I suppose I studied with Sol Schoenbach on the bassoon. There were no bassoon players in Philadelphia and they would always come in with a bassoon player, they'd rather not so they would want to have you know not the big bassoon players in New York come in but I was you know pretty much selected for that actually and at that time it was a good period because if you played four instruments you got paid individually for four instruments until all the trumpet players started to pound you — they started to cut it off at 50% and 25%. But still it was really good because I would do about maybe three or four shows a year and that would certainly be a good income.

MR: You're talking about doubler fees and why was it that the trumpet players —

FT: Because they had one instrument. Well they had perhaps a flugelhorn too but no I had like baritone, the baritone, the bassoon and bass clarinet and I was getting paid individually. So I mean the salaries were like a thousand a week at that time, it was pretty good. I mean as I say they were all individual salaries until the unions cut it all down. But it still was good.

MR: I see. But you had to haul those instruments in and keep them all in working condition.

FT: Of course, yeah, sure.

MR: Touching them every day some people say.

FT: Yep. I'm still doing it right now. I've got it right on the side of me, right?

MR: And of course you had to learn to read bass clef too, for the bassoon.

FT: Oh yeah.

MR: Not a big deal?

FT: No. That was the hardest thing actually. That's the only instrument that I had lessons on actually, well other than that when I was eight years old I had lessons on a clarinet

rehearsals for the concert and it was 33 dollars a month. And I was ready for Curtis at the age of 12.

MR: I see.

FT: But before that I heard Benny Goodman and Artie Shaw. And I says no that's not it, it's going to be jazz.

MR: You're not going to go in the classical Curtis world.

FT: No I'm not.

MR: Yeah. How did you hear music, of course radio was a big thing and did you amass a collection of like 78s when you were a kid?

FT: Eh, 45s too.

MR: 45s.

FT: So that was before the 78s, sure. Yeah but not as much, at that time it was 45s.

MR: I'd really like you to clarify that for me because you're saying that 45s were around before 78s?

FT: Well the 78s, or the LPs, right? Yeah. The large ones. Yeah I still have 45s that I bought at that time, right now.

MR: Okay.

FT: There were a limited amount of tunes on them actually, perhaps one tune actually. Then of course the flip side would give you another tune over there. But if there were three, I'm going to go back there and check it. No I've got 45s, sure.

MR: They're smaller. Yeah I was surprised to get a gift of a donation from someone of Glenn Miller 45s and I didn't even know they existed.

FT: Yep. Well I can tell you that.

MR: Did you aspire to — while you were doing the shows, you're making a good living but musicians often times are, they seem like they're constantly looking for the next thing. Like what I'm doing now is pretty good but I would really like to do — and did you have that feeling that you wanted to do something else?

FT: No not at all, no. I was just particularly concerned of being able to do things that I planned out myself and to be, actually — to use a concept that I'm doing right now and I'm able to teach to students, and to be good in that area.

MR: So what was it that —

FT: You know I'd like to be a great arranger but I'm not schooled for that actually. What I can do is, the way I learned was to you know get all the charts and just see what it was and then that was my — but it would have been good if I'd had another life I think I would you know be an arranger. I mean a musician/arranger such as all the cats that I mentioned.

MR: I know what you mean, arranging is a wonderful thing and you can leave a legacy of charts for other people to play.

FT: That's always good. I always respected even the arrangers and the back-up singers and all that, what they do. I mean that's a hell of a trait I'll tell you that. I mean you've got to be really talented to be able to really do that.

MR: Were you still playing shows about the time that you became enamored with the music of John Coltrane?

FT: Yeah. Yeah that was 1960.

MR: Yes. Can you recall that first exposure to him? Was it live or was it records?

FT: It was live. Well I heard records before that actually but it was live. And I was so interested actually in what he was doing that I had to really — well I had to really find out what he was doing by recordings. Put it that way.

MR: Yes. You felt inspired to carry gear to a place and try to get what he was doing on tape?

FT: Exactly right, yeah.

MR: Did you go home, and I mean this is sort of an obvious question but you went home and like listened to those tapes over and over?

FT: I still do. I still do because he's done some different things. And that's always interesting, I mean continually that's the only — I only hear a few things and that's one which I have on my headphone.

MR: At the time if you were listening to your reels and perhaps you had your saxophone out, I'm trying to form a question here about you're trying to determine what's Coltrane doing here? Is it new or is it just and extension of Charlie Parker? How did you put his playing into your head and make sense of it?

FT: Well I mean he was — he could really inspire to a point by his playing, I mean he was an impressionist I mean there's no question about it, like I mean even if he didn't do like things which you would sit down and try and analyze, he was, his anxiety while he was playing was, I suppose, everybody catched that I'm sure of that.

MR: Can you expand on the word "anxiety?"

FT: Well he can be able to really create to a point you know that it really inspires you. You know it's pretty hard.

MR: Were you trying to relate to his music from a chordal sense? Like what is —

FT: Yeah.

MR: Yeah okay.

FT: The first record that he made was the "Countdown" record. And of course I mean that was the equal division of the twelve tones. And of course that inspired me. And I have a concept you know that I'm able to really use the parts of it and to insert it into the

division of the twelve tones, that you know that they are really playing deceptive inserts before the chord is provided, you know, such as piano players do also as well. There are certain things which you can really be able to have a little more fun playing a half step above, that's pretty well — and of course you have the tritones and but other than that I mean just extracting from the equal divisions of the twelve tones, which is major third, major third, major third.

MR: Yes. He said — you had done an earlier interview with "All About Jazz" I think and you said, "Trane's sequences were in a four-bar period. I've developed it to be used in a short period before a chord is struck."

FT: That's it. I just said that.

MR: You did. And I'm trying to understand it a little better.

FT: Well a related chord, if you were to select it from the division of the twelve tones, which is major third, major third, and a related chord, you can play that and voice lead in and of course go into the chord that is provided for you. Yeah. And you can extract the upper partials of the dominant chords, which is the majors. Major triads. That's — I use major triads when I use the chords and I'm able to really just have a particular way and be able to really construct it chronologically, right from the beginning, and to be able to teach someone to be able to really use it and ultimately after they get it all together it'll come — it'll be almost like second nature.

MR: Interesting. Are there wrong notes or unintended notes in improvising that you hear your students — let me rephrase. If you're listening to them and they're trying to do some of the things you've passed on to them, what constitutes a wrong note?

FT: Well not being able to really know their tonality. That is the most important thing actually because you're able to do deceptive inserts in the voice leading fashion actually, but if you don't know your tonality that distinguishes a wrong note. If — you've got to be very consonant and as I say, so therefore you know if you don't know your tonality that's the part that I generally emphasize actually.

MR: Okay. If you're — forgive me for trying to get a handle on this a little more. If you're doing one of those sort of substitutions where you're playing for a moment a half step above the chord that's going on, but you just used the word "consonant." So how do those two things live together?

FT: Well you know you don't use the blue notes actually, you don't use the flat nines, the — if you use them actually you're going out of context. I mean and if you use them it should be just individually used that way. But I mean so far as the concept is concerned if you use them actually you're in the blue notes already. As I say if you're doing a deceptive insert but before. So therefore you have to be consonant like and just be voice leading, so

actually it doesn't work, it doesn't work. I'm talking about a particular concept now. If you do them individually certainly they work. If you play a minor seven flat five you know then you play I'll just say the Thelonious Monk thing minor seven flat five and you know that's a Locrian and it's simple to really address it as a major third — major third below the dominant.

MR: Okay. So I find it very interesting that you didn't attend the jazz — the higher education jazz program is that correct?

FT: It is correct, yeah.

MR: So this is all your own initiative, your curiosity, and your musicality that has enabled this kind of theoretical knowledge?

FT: Yes, yes, yes. Since I've been doing it actually I feel comfortable and I mean I do feel very comfortable even being able to really teach it to students that come in that pay money to be taught or so — but I mean these are performing students you know, the standard students that come in of course I mean they want to get away by doing the exams and of course I mean they're doing other things other than playing jazz. But I do give them the same process. If they want to just play then I always say, "I know you'd like to be an arranger, you're doing this and all that but you want to play, right?" So yeah the performing students, you know I pound a little more into them because you know I want them to get ahead real quick. And they are playing, at the age of 18 and 19. I've got some students that — pretty scary.

MR: Are their saxophone Gods the same as yours? Like Coltrane died some 55 years ago. Who do they look up to?

FT: Right now? After Coltrane?

MR: Yes.

FT: Well I really don't know because I don't look up to anyone actually. You know my dear friends, I mean you know I think the inspiration that I got from him actually just you know hasn't given me the interest to really hear — I hear everybody of course well I'm talking about really digging into any kind of solos that anybody plays. Right now you have players right now that are just maybe playing contrafacts and tunes and they're you know playing, trying to get as much in as possible. But you know it's nice to hear them but I don't really get right into them actually.

MR: What makes for — in your definition, your personal definition, when does somebody become an innovator in the jazz lexicon?

FT: Well I don't know what you mean by that question. I mean — I mean everybody really does want to make a CD, they want to really be heard. Of course I mean YouTube is hot right now. It's unbelievable that you can hear so many players on YouTube. I guess their

interest is to be coming that way, to be able to get gigs and I guess get into the stage of making the money. I suppose that would be it.

MR: Right. Making the money in jazz.

FT: Well that's hard.

MR: That's a bit of an oxymoron, yeah. Before we leave Coltrane, there was a fella named Paul Currian who wrote some things about your recordings. And he just had this statement about Coltrane and I wanted to read it and see if you have a reaction to it: "Coltrane was aiming for some kind of transcendence, a destination which many of his early fans were simply not interested in following him to, considering the reception given to his later recordings and performances." Did you follow John Coltrane's music all the way to its conclusion as a listener and a fan?

FT: Well my interest was actually how he created this intense feeling of playing. I mean he was an artist. I mean he was almost like, you know he would be able to really just delve on just one of two things you know, not intricate but I mean to get that feeling of, I mean I have some cuts you know that he goes really — it's not — analytically it's not really a big thing but I mean the creation that he really has applied. I mean he was — that was the thing actually I suppose, and everybody does feel that way too when he plays.

MR: What about his later — well not specifically "Ascension" but some of the LPs near the end of his life were — I'm trying to think of the word — sometimes they sounded angry, over the top with Pharoah Sanders and so forth, did this still hold your interest?

FT: No. No now even the club actually there were — there is one name that I don't have over here, the flute player would come in actually and he would play and that would be — and he wouldn't be able to do anything that Trane did actually. It was a little embarrassing.

MR: You're not talking about Eric Dolphy?

FT: Yes I am.

MR: Okay. You mean that was a mountain too tall to stand next to or something like that.

FT: I think so.

MR: Yes. Well I appreciate your thoughts on him. Did you ever get to really meet him? Have a conversation with him?

FT: No. The most amazing thing is that every time I was there he has never really come to the bar. Never. The only time I met him was he was outside, and McCoy Tyner — I engaged him in a lot of gigs that I had because at that time he was 18 years old in Philadelphia. But he was taking Trane home and the trunk was open, Trane was there, and I happened to be there. And that's the only time I said hello. Never saw him other than that. And there are a lot of time in tapes that I do really have that I would expect him to come out and have a beer. Nothing. Never came out. Never came out. Never saw him.

FT: Well I certainly don't like to hear anything like that but not at all. I don't know I mean the — in the condition that he was living in maybe perhaps you would realize that maybe it wasn't good.

MR: Yes. I was thinking to myself John Coltrane and Woody Herman — and they are certainly not opposite ends of the spectrum but normally you wouldn't connect those two things. So when you went with Woody Herman you were already 40 years old is that correct?

FT: Exactly. Yeah I decided to retire and I spent 20 years on the road. That's a laugh.

MR: Yes I was going to say at 40 years some musicians have said I've had enough of this. And so you were launched onto another part of your career which lasted a long time.

FT: Well you know it was a thing which I enjoyed right on through. Woody was, you know I was close to his vintage, one thing actually. And we did a lot of things together, you know a lot of restaurants I did. He and I would get restaurants and I'd tell him you know they were good and let's go. And everything was pretty well — I even cooked for him actually. On the road I was fed up with all the [inaudible]. You had the Coleman case and I would carry a saute pan with a three-quarter pot, I mean a three gallon pot and I would make sauce and one particular time I did it and the guys were playing football outside and I was making the sauce and I was making the spaghetti for them. You know these are things which, and of course when we went up to an area like Montana or something like that there weren't any good restaurants, nothing was available. And I would go out and buy something and I'd really cook for them. That was really great.

MR: Aw. I bet they appreciated that you were like the, you were one of the older guys in the band I would assume.

FT: Yeah.

MR: When you took over the group, and by the way I have to give Mr. Herman a lot of credit for being open-minded about adding new material.

FT: That's the greatest part of that actually, the reason why I stayed there for all of those years is because everybody came in — you take Tony Klatka, Alan Broadbent, Bill Stapleton, they all come in — they wrote what they wanted to and he would just approve it every time. And I mean Alan Vizutti, you know, the trumpet player, he'd come in with the "Fire Dance" and my tunes too. But he wasn't there when my tunes — actually I think so, no, I don't think he ever heard my tunes. But no, I mean you know Fedchock did a lot of arrangements also that well they were great. Everybody was doing things that they liked. And we did, you know before that the band was playing like Richard Evans' "MacArthur Park" and all that. And then I introduced the band with a bassoon and "Giant Steps" and "Countdown." Well the "Countdown" thing was I think at the Monterey Jazz

was planned. All the sessions were planned. But one day before, Woody comes up to me and says, "You know, Frank, we need a hot number." I says, "Have I got a hot number for you." And so we performed it. I wonder if you ever heard of the tune, I don't know if you have.

MR: Yes I have. It was like how much time did you get to rehearse it?

FT: One day before. One day before. I mean you know why? Because we had Stan Getz there, we had Diz, we had Woody Shaw, we had Slide Hampton. Slide Hampton had three charts over there and they were doing all the soloing but the band didn't do anything. And so that's why he came up to me and here I am holding an arrangement that I made for two years and I went, "Do I have something hot for you." I thought that was funny.

MR: Had you actually heard it played before then?

FT: No.

MR: Oh that's a bit of a — I know like my charts I always hear something, oh boy I have to fix that.

FT: No. And actually if you listen to it I've been using division of twelve tones, equal division of twelve tones on it actually if you really — I incorporated all that actually. I mean they were only a couple of things that I wrote but every time I wrote something as I say it was only for my solos.

MR: I think I read that when a new person came on that Woody would sort of give them a trial? Would hire them for a period of time to see if they were going to fit in?

FT: Well you know he would have them play and of course I mean if they weren't good you know at that time you could buy tickets at the airport right at the counter. So I mean he would let them go. But one example was — oh God, my friend — Oh I'm trying to think —Joe Lovano.

MR: Joe Lovano.

FT: Joe Lovano was playing with the group and then he was hired for the first night and he sat in and he played and he got up and took a solo and after the night was over Woody come up to me and said, "What do you think?" I says, "Well did you hear his solo?" So he was there for three years. My dear friend.

MR: There's a marvelous video of you and Joe on "Giant Steps" I think it's from '77 or so —

FT: I know that was —

MR: And when I'm listening to that sometimes I wonder are you two fellas — what are you thinking about? Are you thinking the changes as they go by? Or is there more of a direct connection between your fingers and something that you've internalized?

FT: No we're definitely thinking of the chords of course. There's no question about that. And you know performing more interval jumps you know to make it really effective, that we were playing together you're talking about, right?

MR: Yeah.

FT: And we were almost like trading. And it's encouraging to do something like that. At that particular time you know we were in Europe. And Europe, they can expand tunes like really long or so, just at that particular time. And so I kind of figured I extended it actually and I didn't — you know I just went right on and Woody was there with his hands down and just you know really enjoying it actually. And for that length of time to play a tune was — it was a trading thing at the end of the tune of course.

MR: Yes.

FT: And Woody really enjoyed it actually. I kind of figured well it's Europe you know so let's do it that way.

MR: Because Europe had more hipper audiences?

FT: Well they, I mean not hipper audiences but I mean we had times you know when they played up until eight or nine in the morning actually. They were really into jazz. I mean they — particularly they really favor playing long.

MR: Well as long as you mentioned that, maybe I'll ask your opinion about the state of jazz in America at this point. We have hundreds of universities with fine jazz programs, of course you're part of one of the major ones. But on the other end sales of recordings and live, the club scene, has changed a lot. Do you have any opinions about where jazz is at right now?

FT: Well for the past two years I mean it's obvious that things have really closed right on through. That's the particular thing about even teaching jazz you know, where are they going to be playing and to what area would they be getting into? We at that time, when we were traveling and playing every night it was always colleges, it was always schools. Because they didn't have any bands as they have right now actually. I mean in Berklee right now we have three bands that are operating. Now as I say but at that time, but not right now, that canceled us, the big bands. That was the thing that really right now canceled us, outside of the money that has to be paid for musicians.

MR: Can I ask you to say that again? What was it that canceled you?

FT: The — what was I —

MR: Maybe you were saying there was more of a market because the colleges did not yet have the bands of their own?

FT: Exactly right. Sure.

MR: All right.

FT: They didn't have any bands actually. They didn't have that much of a curriculum. And the high schools also as well, they might have had a few musicians you know but not jazz bands. So a lot of them, we got canceled pretty much when I mean who needs the Woody Herman band at Berklee right now, where — I don't know. Or other bands actually. But I don't know how Berklee hires the bands. I think they, I think most of the bands have to really support themselves. I think so, I don't know.

MR: Are you able or do you think it's even relevant to teach students about the bandstand? About professionalism? About getting a gig and keeping it? Or is that not even as relevant anymore?

FT: Well at first I mean there are not many bands that are operating right now. You know, like as there were before. The musicians would be going through just switching a lot of bands at that particular time. But you know you're talking about all the places that you will be able to really play or be hired actually, all the venues such as the Earle Theater and the Atlantic City Steel Pier — all these things are not operating right now. These were the things which everybody looked forward to be able to go with the band. Like you're talking about the 400 bands that were operating at that time. And then there were also local bands too also that were operating.

MR: So all the students that graduate every year from the universities if they come and ask for your advice about making a living, do you have anything you can tell them these days?

FT: Well I would say to you know other areas in the music business actually they'd be able to focus on too also as well. I mean such as arranging and of course I mean there's an A&R man or you know as I say always have something that you can really have on the side actually because you know it'd be pretty hard to live as a jazz player unless you are able to really get yourself a good group and a good agent and a good recording, a good CD and a lot of distribution and that takes time but it works. That's the way that one has to really do it that way. I mean get all your things on YouTube. I mean and then you play all the clubs in New York or — there are no clubs anymore in Philadelphia. That's a big drag. You know at that time it was the Blue Note, the Show Boat, the Pep's Musical Bar and all that. They're not around. That's where — I'll give you just — The Rendezvous I remember on Market Street actually, in the afternoon they had like some sort of a subtle jazz club. And I went in and I looked and who was sitting on a high chair was Charlie Parker and playing a plastic saxophone with his leg in a cast. I nearly fell over. I can't believe that.

MR: Was it an actual gig for him or was he just like —

FT: He was up there, he was playing, yeah. Yeah. It was like it wasn't a big showplace or anything it was just a local bar right in the center of town and here he was with a cast and

MR: That's interesting because so many people, so many saxophone players did all they could to play like him but I don't think the plastic saxophone was part of the routine.

FT: No. But he could play anything. He could probably whistle I suppose, and sound good.

MR: Yeah. When you were actually leading the Woody Herman group did you find yourself having to be a disciplinarian?

FT: I was pretty well straight I can tell you that. There were so many things that I had to really remember you know and we had cats that we had that hadn't played with the band and I would have to have Mike Brignola, who was the road manager, he would give me a sheet to be able to you know check out who's playing in what seat and I would have to be looking at — then of course I'd have to be leading the band and selecting the tunes also. But that was a thing which as I say I had to be really really straight and I wouldn't drink any wine or anything before that. It would always have to come after. No you know as I say I mean I wouldn't even eat before that actually because I just felt to be that way actually.

MR: Did you get the best seat on the bus?

FT: The front one, yeah. Not when Woody was there, Woody had the best seat.

MR: It's too bad he had such a bad experience with finances and so forth. Do you think it wore him down?

FT: No. No. It didn't even faze him. Really it didn't. He never really complained about it or anything. No. Never. Never. He just went on with — he loved his cheese sandwich at night after the gig and he had this vodka in the bin on the bus and really he always looked forward to that. No of course I mean he never complained about anything, about all his money or anything like that and all the problems that he went through. You know they got his house and all that sort of thing you know, up in Beverly Hills. I don't know. No, he never felt really that it was bothering him too much.

MR: That's a good way to be.

FT: He just loved to play. And he was a great clarinet player at the beginning. He played a lot of good things. I mean his alto playing I mean he admired Johnny Hodges. He was just as slurpy as Johnny. I mean he could tie a note and sail up to it.

MR: I think there's a good chance I saw you with the band around 19 — it could have been '69 or '70 in Rochester, New York.

FT: '69 or '70.

MR: It was outside and I always remember that Woody played the alto without a neck strap. It's funny the things you remember.

FT: Oh God I don't know. We played at a club one time and they have five dancers and they grabbed — the one was falling and they grabbed his horn. And the neck was like this and

all I did was close the octave thing and I gave it to him. And he was just playing as if nothing really happened.

MR: Did you ever — is there anything in your memory like a train wreck type of gig either from the travel or logistics or you know something lost their music? Does anything like pop into your head?

FT: No not really, no. No everything was pretty well organized I think. Mike Brignola had a lot of things to do about that actually. He would always, you know the music was always taken care of and everything was pretty well organized. I never had any problems like that.

MR: That's nice to hear.

FT: Yeah.

MR: You mentioned that you are looking at a lot of notes to yourself.

FT: A lot of notes.

MR: For this interview and I wonder if there's something I haven't asked about that you'd like to —

FT: Well I was with Benny Goodman.

MR: Um hum.

FT: And of course he called me "Cheech." And if he called you by your nickname then he liked you. I mean there were a lot of players with me: Kenny Burrell, Ruby Braff, Doc Severinsen. And of course we went on the road with Urbie Green. These were some of the things actually. But another thing actually was I was a good repairman too. Benny Carter, every time we did the Norwegian he would always call me into his room and I had to change a pad you know. And this happened twice. And oh Gerry Mulligan had a gig of a concert and we were following him in New York and one of the players said the post on his horn broke, on the baritone, he couldn't play. And one of the players said, "Frank is coming in" because he knew me you know he played with our band and he said, "When he comes in he'll fix it." I did. I grabbed it and I soldered the post and he played.

MR: That's a great way to be in good with other musicians. Save their horns.

FT: I did. I fixed Al Cohn's horn also as well. And actually let's see, up in — my note over here it seems like I remember — oh the reason why I went with Benny Goodman was Wardell Gray you know. He liked the way —

MR: Wardell Gray.

FT: And so I played maybe like him at that time actually. I was sort of like Zoot and Al and that's the reason why I got called. A friend, a photographer named Bootsie told Benny that you've got to hear this guy or something like this, and I got the gig. But what's his

knock on the door and it's Charles Lloyd and his B key was hanging. And he says, "Frank, I've got a gig tonight." And you know, "Can you do something for me?" I fixed his horn too.

MR: Charles Lloyd.

FT: Charles Lloyd.

MR: I think it's a wonderful connection that you heard Benny Goodman which made you take an off ramp from the classical world into jazz and then you got to play with him.

FT: Yeah that's right. Yeah. There are some exciting moments also.

MR: Was he as absent minded as many of those stories indicate?

FT: Well you know at that stage of the game I think he was a little old then, he wasn't just as great as he was actually. But I mean it was only like the concert that we had around — it was an outside concert with the group, with a small group, we had a couple of concerts with the small group and the band also. But after that he didn't really attend too much. It was Urbie Green that took the band out on the road, with the Benny Goodman band.

MR: And how much playing are you doing yourself these days?

FT: Well George and I have a concert going up in Rochester at the jazz festival.

MR: That's a beautiful jazz festival they have.

FT: Yeah John Nugent is the — and then there's a club over here which is a Chinese place, or a Japanese place it's called the Monk, we've got a gig over there actually. And something else came up, and I have a few. So I keep myself pretty much occupied and practicing.

MR: Yeah I'm looking at a quote here from an earlier interview: "Even at my age I have a duffel bag packed and I'm ready to go."

FT: My age, right? Oh boy. It's a little hard actually but I don't really feel as if I'm in the stage of — well I'm in the 93rd year. Of course I'm not 93 years old until December. And I just, it's hard to move of course but I just function just as well as I feel as if I'm 60 or 70. I mean I don't really feel anything — I haven't really accepted that I'm that age. And I walk on glass of course. I'm really careful.

MR: To wrap up, if you had the opportunity — let's say an author was doing a jazz biography book and he wanted to do a piece on you, sort of like the *Encyclopedia of Jazz*, what would you like to see written about your own playing? You see descriptions of people's playing and I'm wondering if there's something that would please you if it was written?

FT: Well it might be that maybe perhaps I would be able to do something different that they can enjoy it and they can be just as concerned in the way I was, like with Trane. I mean there are so many great players right now even as well. But I try to keep myself in a position where I'm able to even enjoy myself and play some of the things that are through my concept as I stated, the, as I say, some of the things I'm creating over here and trying

MR: Things that you've written down and that you've worked out in your head and then you've written them down for other people to use.

FT: They're all on Finale, they're all on BandBox, Band in a Box actually, and I have another program with better sounds. I have all — I have all of the soloists that have performed all the tunes that I have in there and also I have many of the Lennie Tristano tunes, I have about 20 or 25, and I write them all and I write them all in concert alto and tenor, where many teachers only give you a concert part and they say, "Go ahead and play jazz."

MR: I can't even —

FT: If I saw a concert part with chords it takes away — it takes away from me actually. You know I've got to remember what the chord was and I've got to transpose it, and then I've got to play.

MR: Yeah, that's a big added step.

FT: It is. I'm telling you that's it. Especially, I mean look I can transpose alto parts but if I had to really transpose alto chords, never. Never.

MR: Yeah. You just gave me a flash. I attended an improv workshop after I graduated from college and this fella's approach was this was in a roomful of improvisers. Some people had never even done it. And he passed out "Giant Steps" in the concert key and he expected everybody to play it. And the results were not pretty, I can tell you that.

FT: Never. I know that. I know that even just last week I had a student that wanted to play a tune and he said he had the tune but the back tracking was on his iPhone you know. And all the back tracks that I do actually are pretty much with strings and everything and all that, a little more encouragement. And he had a concert part. And I says, "Noah," I says, "I'm not going to play a concert because I don't like it." You know I wouldn't be able to perform exactly what I know. I'd have to transpose it first and then I've got to remember some of the concept things that I teach. I can't do it. I mean you know you know if you see a C chord maybe you know it's a D. But I mean if you go like a minor seven flat five then, or a major seven flat five or something like that — and then of course there are devices that I use for them incidentally. In other words you don't practice on a minor seven flat five. It's a Locrian.

MR: Right.

FT: So you practice on the dominant. You don't practice on the major seven flat five because I mean one tone higher it's a dominant.

MR: I see. Well if we ever do a gig together I'm going to remember to being transposed parts for you.

FT: Right. But I do, I mean it's a lot of effort but I enjoy doing it actually so this way they're able to really — and everybody, most of the piano players or most of the teachers do give

MR: Yeah. It gets in the way.

FT: Oh yeah. It surely does.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time today. It was really enjoyable to speak with you and as I opened up with you've made a real contribution to this music and I appreciate it as do many people.

FT: Well I hope I did, you know, contribute and able to really explain some things actually, and it's a pleasure.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.

FT: Okay.

MR: I'm just going to pause our recording here and then we'll say good-bye.

FT: Okay, Monk. Bye-bye now.

MR: Okay. We are out — I think we're out.

FT: All right.